Self-Hosting Frontier LLMs on Nebius — Reasoning per Dollar

Executive brief · prepared 13 July 2026 · using won Nebius GPU credits · all prices Nebius preemptible unless noted

> **The question this answers:** of today's open-weight LLMs, which one gives the most reasoning ability per dollar of GPU time — and what does running it actually cost per month at real usage levels? Reasoning is scored by the **Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index v4.1** (a neutral third party that runs the same 9 hard reasoning & long-horizon evals — HLE, GPQA-Diamond, Terminal-Bench, long-context reasoning, etc. — identically on every model). Cost is Nebius's live GPU rate on the cheapest configuration that fits each model.

◆ BEST VALUE — PICK THIS

DeepSeek V4 Flash

1×B200 · reasoning index 40 (11 pts off the best) · full 1M context on one GPU

$474 / mo @ 4h/day

$3.95/hr · ~2× the reasoning-per-$ of anything else

▲ TOP REASONING

GLM-5.2 (MIT license)

4×H200 · reasoning index 51 · #1 open-weight model

$1,176 / mo @ 4h/day

$9.80/hr · buy only if you need the very top

✕ AVOID

DeepSeek V4 Pro

8×H200 · reasoning index 44 — same as models costing 1/5 as much

$2,352 / mo @ 4h/day

$19.60/hr · 5× the price for ~4 extra index points

Bottom line: **DeepSeek V4 Flash on a single B200 is the clear buy** — near-top reasoning at the lowest serious price. Reach for GLM-5.2 only when you need the absolute best open reasoning, and **skip the 1.6T DeepSeek V4 Pro**: it barely out-reasons its own Flash sibling while costing five times as much. Credits are locked to the Nebius account, so this compares options *within* Nebius.

1 · Reasoning per dollar — the ranking

Bar = reasoning index ÷ preemptible $/hr (higher is better). Only models with a confirmed v4.1 index shown.



The two leaders (Flash, Nemotron) share a trait: **cheap-KV architectures** (MLA and Mamba-2). The same design that keeps them cheap to host also makes long chains of thought cheap to run — so the reasoning-value winners and the hosting-cost winners are the same models. DeepSeek V4 Pro sits at the bottom: a full 8-GPU node for a score its own single-GPU Flash nearly matches.

2 · What it costs — monthly by usage level

Preemptible $/hr on the cheapest fitting Nebius config, ×hours×30 days. Preemptible ≈ 44% below on-demand but can be interrupted — fine for batch/dev, use on-demand (~1.8–2×) for an always-on production endpoint.

Model / config	$/hr	Reason idx	2h/day	4h/day	6h/day	8h/day	12h/day	24h/day
DeepSeek V4 Flash BEST VALUE 284B / 13B · MLA · 1M ctx · 1×B200	$3.95	**40**	$237	$474	$711	$948	$1,422	$2,844
GLM-5.2 TOP REASONING 744B / 40B · MLA+DSA · MIT · 4×H200	$9.80	**51**	$588	$1,176	$1,764	$2,352	$3,528	$7,056
Hunyuan Hy3 VERIFY 295B / 21B · GQA · Apache-2 · 2×H200	$4.90	—	$294	$588	$882	$1,176	$1,764	$3,528
Nemotron 3 Ultra 550B / 55B · Mamba-2 · NVFP4 · 2×B200	$7.90	**48**	$474	$948	$1,422	$1,896	$2,844	$5,688
Kimi K2.6 1T / 32B · MLA · 4×H200	$9.80	**43**	$588	$1,176	$1,764	$2,352	$3,528	$7,056
MiniMax-M3 428B / 23B · MSA (KV-heavy) · 4×H200	$9.80	**44**	$588	$1,176	$1,764	$2,352	$3,528	$7,056
DeepSeek V4 Pro POOR VALUE 1.6T / 49B · MLA · 1M ctx · 8×H200	$19.60	**44**	$1,176	$2,352	$3,528	$4,704	$7,056	$14,112
GLM-4.5-Air BUDGET 106B / 12B · prior-gen · 1×RTX PRO 6000	$0.95	—	$57	$114	$171	$228	$342	$684

How to read it: the two columns your team asked about are **4h/day** and **6h/day**. At 6h/day, the value pick (Flash) is $711/mo; the top-reasoning pick (GLM-5.2) is $1,764/mo; the flagship Pro is $3,528/mo. GLM-4.5-Air is the floor for light/bulk work but is prior-generation (weaker reasoning).

3 · Credit runway — how long the award lasts

Illustrative: months of use per **$10,000** of credits. Scale to your actual award amount.

Model (config)	Cost @4h/day	Runway /$10k	Cost @6h/day	Runway /$10k
DeepSeek V4 Flash (1×B200)	$474	21.1 mo	$711	14.1 mo
GLM-5.2 (4×H200)	$1,176	8.5 mo	$1,764	5.7 mo
Hunyuan Hy3 (2×H200)	$588	17.0 mo	$882	11.3 mo
Nemotron 3 Ultra (2×B200)	$948	10.5 mo	$1,422	7.0 mo
DeepSeek V4 Pro (8×H200)	$2,352	4.3 mo	$3,528	2.8 mo

e.g. a $10k pool runs **DeepSeek V4 Flash** for over a year at 6h/day, but only ~3 months of the 1.6T Pro. The value pick doesn't just cost less per hour — it multiplies how far the award goes.

4 · Reference — Nebius GPU pricing & model fit

Nebius self-serve rates, $/GPU-hr, effective 1 Jun 2026 (nebius.com/prices). No A100/Ampere tier is sold.

GPU	VRAM	On-demand	Preemptible
HGX B300	288 GB	$7.85	$4.30
HGX B200	180 GB	$7.15	$3.95
HGX H200	141 GB	$4.50	$2.45
HGX H100	80 GB	$3.85	$2.15
RTX PRO 6000	96 GB	$1.80	$0.95
L40S	48 GB	from $1.55	from $0.74

Why each model lands on its config — fit is set by attention architecture, not parameter count:

- **MLA models** (DeepSeek V4 Flash/Pro, GLM-5.2, Kimi) compress the KV cache ~50× → huge contexts on few GPUs. Flash serves a full 1M context on **one** B200; the 1.6T Pro fits a single 8-GPU node.
- **Mamba-2** (Nemotron) makes long context nearly free, but its NVFP4 weights are **Blackwell-only** — needs B200/B300, not H200.
- **MSA** (MiniMax-M3) does **not** compress KV — it needs far more GPU at long context than its size suggests.
- **Plain GQA** (GLM-4.5-Air, Qwen3-235B, Hunyuan Hy3) is cleanly sized; fine at their native contexts.

5 · Method, caveats & sources

- **Reasoning score** = Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index v4.1 (Jul 2026), run identically across models. Confirmed: GLM-5.2 51 · Nemotron 3 Ultra 48 · MiniMax-M3 44 · DeepSeek V4 Pro 44 · Kimi K2.6 43 · DeepSeek V4 Flash 40. For scale, the closed frontier (GPT-5.6 ~59, Claude Opus 4.8 ~56) leads the best open model by ~8 pts.
- VERIFY **Hunyuan Hy3** posts a frontier GPQA-Diamond (90.4) at only $4.90/hr but has **no confirmed index** — potentially a top value pick; confirm before committing.
- **Prior-gen** GLM-4.5-Air & Qwen3-235B (2025) are cheap but score below the 2026 flagships on the current hard index; use for light/bulk work only.
- **Prices** are Nebius's live page (13 Jul 2026), preemptible. **Credits are Nebius-account-locked** — they can't move to a cheaper competitor, so optimise within Nebius (preemptible + reserved).
- **Some individual scores lean on secondary sources**; the AA Index values and Nebius prices are the firm figures. Full working: docs/research/nebius-gpu-llm-serving-2026.md.

Sources: Artificial Analysis Intelligence Index v4.1 · nebius.com/prices & docs.nebius.com · lab primary reports (arXiv/HuggingFace) for GLM-5.2, Kimi K2, Qwen3-235B, GLM-4.5-Air, Nemotron 3 Ultra, DeepSeek V4, Hunyuan 3.0. Reasoning scores are third-party composite; validate on your own evals before production commitment.